knowing that Ben Bella's next stop after Washington would be Havana, Kennedy tried to use him to pass a message to Castro. He told the Algerian leader that he was prepared to make peace with the "national communist" regime in Cuba as long as Castro did not try to challenge the status quo in Latin America. When Ben Bella asked whether Kennedy had in mind a regime like those in Yugoslavia or Poland, Kennedy responded in the affirmative. He also told Ben Bella what was unacceptable to his administration: the transformation of Cuba into a Soviet military base armed with offensive weapons, and efforts to spread communist revolution in the rest of Latin America. Kennedy was offering Castro a deal without saying so openly.[2]

But anyone who looked at the front page of the *New York Times* that morning realized that Kennedy's room for maneuver on Cuba was limited. He was under growing pressure to act against the Castro regime. "Eisenhower Calls President Weak on Foreign Policy," went the headline of a report on Eisenhower's address at a Republican dinner in Kennedy's stronghold of Boston. The former president, who had hitherto kept his criticism of Kennedy and his administration to himself, broke the unwritten rule of not criticizing his successor and rejected Kennedy's earlier assertion that his administration had ignored Latin America for eight years. "In those eight years we lost no inch of ground to tyranny," wrote the *Times*, quoting Eisenhower. "We witnessed no abdication of international responsibility. We accepted no compromise of pledged word or withdrawal from principle. No walls were built, no threatening foreign bases were established."[3]

The reference to the wall was a dig at Kennedy's tacit acceptance of the Berlin Wall. The reference to military bases was a clear hint at Cuba. Anyone who followed media coverage of the growing Cuban controversy knew that Kenneth Keating, Republican senator from New York, was claiming day in and day out that there were in fact nuclear-armed missiles in Cuba and that the administration was doing nothing to deal with the threat. It did not look good for the president. The 1962 congressional elections were getting into high gear, and the Republicans had enlisted the most powerful weapon in their arsenal, the former president. He toured the country endorsing Republican candidates for Congress and attacking Democratic ones, including Jack Kennedy's youngest brother, Edward, who